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Racial Colonists in the Nazi East: Disabled Veterans and the Malleable Boundaries of Race, Masculinity, and Disability

Christopher Thomas Goodwin 

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, USA

Email: ctg3@illinois.edu

Abstract

The Wehrmacht's stunning victories in the first three years of the Second World War produced a euphoric response among Nazi leaders. Suddenly, the East became a vast expanse of nearly limitless possibilities, and creating a new racial order topped the list. Although most historians have focused on the *Volksdeutsche*, the regime also planned to settle veterans after the war's conclusion to serve as model Germans, farmers, and a "living wall" to defend the East. As the war dragged on into 1942 and these men continued to fight, the regime turned to disabled veterans to garrison the East. The SS designed a racial selection process that proved too restrictive to generate enough applicants and, during 1943 and 1944, settlement officials revised standards. In the process, contingency, constrained practices, and contested ideology all cast the boundaries of race, gender, sexuality, able-bodiedness, and disability as much more malleable than Nazi propaganda projected.

Keywords: Disability; masculinity; ideology; National Socialism; race; Second World War

On May 9, 1943, the *Ostdeutscher Beobachter* published the article "War-Disabled as Farmers in Wartheland."¹ The journalist Eugen Petrull noted that the Gauleiter of this land recently conquered from Poland, Arthur Greiser, intended his region to become a "Gau of front-line soldiers." To do this, he would settle men with military experience who could no longer serve in the Wehrmacht during the present war: physically disabled veterans released from military service. War veterans had acquired sixty farms in the Gau in just the past eight months. More farms could have been handed over—but many properties lacked a "mas-sive house ... that would be suitable ... for a German" and "Polish dereliction," and mismanagement had left most farms in a state of disrepair. Despair not, the reporter assured readers, Heinrich Himmler, head of the *Schutzstaffel* (SS) and Reich Commissioner for the Consolidation of German Nationality (RKFDV), had organized a tour of the farms, and the disabled veterans had already set about bringing German "peace and order" (*Ruhe und Ordnung*) to their extensive plots of land. Farmer Janke, a veteran of three campaigns unable to walk without a cane, planned to tear down a half-ruined shack and "build a proper poultry house in its place." If readers doubted the likelihood of his managing such physically demanding tasks, one need only notice "his young, squeaky-clean wife" whose "energetic face" proclaimed, "Just you wait ... I'll help you get the farm in order and keep it in order, too."²

¹ Please note that throughout, all translations are my own unless stated otherwise.

² Eugen Petrull, "Kriegsversehrte als Bauern im Wartheland," *Ostdeutscher Beobachter*, May 9, 1943.

Farmer Janke was one of several thousand disabled veterans who joined the colonizing mission to establish a new racial order in Europe. The euphoria of the victorious campaigns from 1939 to 1941 had seized men like the eastern researcher (*Ostforscher*) Franz Lüdtke, who boldly stated that “our Eastern Land has finally been liberated” and that “the East of the new millennium stands under the sign of the swastika.”³ Over the course of 1941 and 1942, the SS’s ambitions swelled into the *Generalsiedlungsplan* (General Settlement Plan).⁴ “Liberated” lands now stretched as far east as a line running from the cold Baltic Sea southward to the Black Sea’s warm waters and its Crimean paradise. The site of this would-be German utopia included 48 million “undesirable people.”⁵ The regime would drive 31 million of them farther east and out of the empire, while 17 million would suffer physical elimination.⁶ These astonishing numbers did not include the estimated 11.3 million Jews in the area. Depopulation would coincide with repopulation. The regime marked millions of *Volksdeutsche* (ethnic Germans) for providing the raw biological material to settle the East. After hundreds of years, Nazi leaders envisioned, 600 million Nordic Germans would have occupied, settled, and cleansed the region, a sweeping racial reordering of Europe.⁷

Beginning in 1942, disabled veterans served as a vanguard for this continental transformation. But ideology ground roughly against practice as the regime implemented resettlement plans over the course of 1943 and 1944. Stringent ideological requirements of race, gender, and disability collided with the reality of drumming up enough willing applicants, let alone men who checked each box of Germanness. As military victory slipped away, settlement officials pushed forward with the human material they had on hand. Men like Farmer Janke, who served as racial pioneers, looked altogether different from the ideals the SS outlined in 1942. The next two years saw negotiations, complications, and ideological retreats. The disabled veteran was the site of this negotiation as Nazi officials wrangled with one another to fit the veteran’s maimed and unwhole body into the propagandized mold of his able-bodied counterpart, the soldier. This article argues that contingency, constrained practices, and contested ideology all cast the boundaries of race, gender, sexuality, able-bodiedness, and disability as much more fluid than Nazi leaders and SS officials originally envisioned for their eastern utopia. Disabled veteran as racial colonist disrupts the conventional view that disabled veterans figured for the regime only as pension-seeking threats to financial solvency or as less-productive, but unfortunately essential, workers in a time of total war.⁸ Likewise, the Nazi attempt to recruit disabled veterans and the men’s own volunteering for the eastern colonization scheme illustrate challenges to Nazi binaries of healthy and sick, beautiful and ugly, German and non-German.⁹ The regime hailed physically disabled veterans as heroes in propaganda, but their bodies sometimes more closely resembled those marked for ideological and physical destruction. The contingencies of war loosened

³ Franz Lüdtke, *Ein Jahrtausend Krieg zwischen Deutschland und Polen* (Stuttgart: Robert Lutz Nachfolger/Inhaber Rudolf Weisert, 1941), 8.

⁴ Mechtild Rössler, et al, ed., *Der “Generalplan Ost.” Hauptlinien der nationalsozialistischen Planungs- und Vernichtungspolitik* (Berlin: Akademie, 1993); Czesław Madajczyk, *Vom Generalplan Ost zum Generalsiedlungsplan* (Munich: K. G. Saur, 1994).

⁵ Christian Ingrao, *The Promise of the East: Nazi Hopes and Genocide, 1939–43*, trans. Andrew Brown (Cambridge: Polity Books, 2019), 115.

⁶ Ingrao, *The Promise of the East*.

⁷ Ingrao, *The Promise of the East*, 224.

⁸ James M. Diehl, “Change and Continuity in the Treatment of German Kriegsopfer,” *Central European History* 18, no. 2 (1985): 170–87; James M. Diehl, “Victors or Victims? Disabled Veterans in the Third Reich,” *Journal of Modern History* 59, no. 4 (1987): 705–36; James M. Diehl, *The Thanks of the Fatherland: German Veterans after the Second World War* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1993); Deborah Cohen, *The War Come Home: Disabled Veterans in Britain and Germany, 1914–1939* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2001); Nils Löffelbein, *Ehrenbürger der Nation. Die Kriegsbeschädigten des Ersten Weltkriegs in Politik und Propaganda des Nationalsozialismus* (Essen: Klartext, 2013).

⁹ Carol Poore, *Disability in Twentieth-Century German Culture* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2007), 67–138.

the strict SS selection process over time and sanctioned new modes of embodiment suitable for representing and protecting the German race.

The centrality of acquiring territory in the Nazi war plans is, of course, nothing new for historians. Early works framed the war in the East as a case of traditional empire-building using modern techniques.¹⁰ *Bevölkerungspolitik* (population policy) shrouded racial goals with a veneer of scientific justification, and modern technology provided a means to transfer populations on a massive scale. The reorientation toward seeing the Third Reich as a “racial state” shifted historians’ attention away from the top leadership toward groups actually implementing ideology, including a cohort of mid-level SS officers and the large population of *Volksdeutsche* they shuffled around eastern Europe.¹¹ Rather than being lured by the regime into compliance with cynical propaganda and platitudes, for many Germans, Nazi ideology became entangled with desires, beliefs, and lived experience. Binaries such as perpetrator-victim have fallen away in more recent scholarship, revealing the nuanced ways Germans accepted, adhered to, failed to adhere to, and rejected Nazi ideology. Where a generation ago historians wrote simply of Nazi Germany as a bastion of male power, historians such as Thomas Kühne now identify hegemonic masculinities and, crucially, alternative masculinities.¹² Social status and position, confession, sexuality, and race all inflected masculinity to produce alternative ways of navigating a dangerously racist society and a deadly war, even as these alternatives oriented themselves in relation to the hegemonic ideal of the aggressive, strong, and disciplined soldier. How closely a man aligned himself with martial values proved the “yardstick against which a man’s worth was measured.”¹³ Historiographically, Nazi plans to subjugate and transform eastern Europe now come bundled with the limits of racial indoctrination and the persuasive power of ideology, generational conflicts and continuities, individuals’ anxieties and ambitions, and the embracing of and resistance to pervasive structures of gender and sexuality.

Rarely noted is that the hegemonic masculine ideal, the soldier, played a crucial role in Nazi Germany’s *Generalsiedlungsplan*. The *Volksdeutsche* provided the mass of *Menschenmaterial* to colonize the East, but settlement authorities quickly became disillusioned when they encountered “Germans” who could barely speak the German language, if at all, and who seemed alien in their behavior and supposed lack of German hygiene.¹⁴ Historians have enumerated the issues involved in the SS’s attempt to divide and select only the best racial

¹⁰ Robert L. Koehl, *RKFDV: German Resettlement and Population Policy, 1939–1945* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1957), 1.

¹¹ Alexander Dallin, *German Rule in Russia, 1941–1945: A Study of Occupation Policies* (Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 1981); Rolf-Dieter Müller, *Hitlers Ostkrieg und die deutsche Siedlungspolitik. Die Zusammenarbeit von Wehrmacht, Wirtschaft, und SS* (Frankfurt/Main: Fischer, 1991); Valdis O. Lumans, *Himmler’s Auxiliaries: The Volksdeutsche Mittelstelle and the German National Minorities of Europe, 1933–1945* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1993); Michael Wildt, *Generation des Unbedingten. Das Führungskorps des Reichssicherheitshauptamtes* (Hamburg: Hamburger Edition, 2002); Isabel Heinemann, “Rasse, Siedlung, deutsches Blut.” *Das Rasse- und Siedlungshauptamt der SS und die rassenpolitische Neuordnung Europas* (Göttingen: Wallstein, 2003).

¹² Thomas Kühne, “Protean Masculinity, Hegemonic Masculinity: Soldiers in the Third Reich,” *Central European History* 51, no. 3 (2018): 394. See also Anette Dietrich and Ljiljana Heise, *Männlichkeitskonstruktionen im Nationalsozialismus. Formen, Funktionen und Wirkungsmacht von Geschlechterkonstruktionen im Nationalsozialismus und ihre Reflexion in der pädagogischen Praxis* (Frankfurt/Main: Peter Lang, 2013); Bernhard Gotto and Elke Seefried, *Männer mit “Makel.” Männlichkeiten und gesellschaftlicher Wandel in der frühen Bundesrepublik* (Oldenbourg: De Gruyter, 2017); Thomas Kühne, *The Rise and Fall of Comradeship: Hitler’s Soldiers, Male Bonding and Mass Violence in the Twentieth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017); Jason Crouthamel, “Homosexuality and Comradeship: Destabilizing the Hegemonic Masculine Ideal in Nazi Germany,” *Central European History* 51, no. 3 (2018): 419–39.

¹³ Michael J. Geheran, “Remasculinizing the Shirker: The Jewish *Frontkämpfer* under Hitler,” *Central European History* 51, no. 3 (2018): 444.

¹⁴ Elizabeth Harvey, *Women and the Nazi East: Agents and Witnesses of Germanization* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2003), 158.

material from the mass of *Volksdeutsche*.¹⁵ But racial science provided no definitive biological characteristics to ensure exact classifications. The transformation of these people into true Germans would be the work of generations. Hitler's anxiety flared that he might win the war against the Soviet Union only to lose everything in a "wave ... foaming down from Asia" that would surprise "a Europe numbed by civilization."¹⁶ Rather than a wall of brick and mortar to dam the flood, he railed that "we must meet it with a living wall."¹⁷ Another *Ostforscher*, Theodor Oberländer, opined that the living wall, a biological boundary between peoples, should be stocked by men "willing to sacrifice and fight, whose highest aim in life is to settle the new soil and take root in it."¹⁸ These warrior-farmers (*Wehrbauern*) would spurn "compromises and ... half-measures" as they prosecuted Germany's mission in the East.¹⁹ After the Soviet Union fell and the Allies sued for peace, the soldier would move on to his next role as a veteran who colonized and defended the Nazi East.

But in 1942 the Soviet Union doggedly resisted defeat, and the Allies jabbed at Germany wherever they could. The ideal settler still fought on the front line, and it was altogether unclear when he might become available for his next duty. As 1942 eclipsed into 1943 and military setbacks foreclosed utopic dreams, an opportunity presented itself. Rather than waiting for a successful conclusion of the war and the expected flood of settlement applications from able-bodied war veterans, disabled veterans could settle, hold the line as defenders of the East, and act as model Germans for the *Volksdeutsche*—at least until their able-bodied counterparts could arrive after the war. These men had all suffered physical impairments as a result of woundings in the First, but primarily the Second, World Wars. Nazi policy excluded men with known psychological wounds.²⁰ The veterans had all been released from the Wehrmacht and entered the pension system. The regime had, therefore, administratively labeled them as "disabled," a legal appellation with all the consequences in German society for men with amputated limbs, unseeing eyes, disfigured faces, the physical markers and visible memories of the ravages of war.²¹ In the historiography, able-bodiedness—and what constituted able-bodiedness—is taken as a self-evident aspect of the Nazi masculine ideal. Nazi propaganda claimed as much in its numerous pictures and films, which contrasted whole, complete, and beautiful "healthy bodies" with broken, dirty, and macabre "disabled bodies." But when the SS began drawing up the disabled veteran settlement application process, their careful work to delineate standards of racial heritage, personality characteristics, fertility, and able-bodiedness produced a vision of the ideal settler that differed markedly from the ideal soldier. After all, the social profile of the Wehrmacht as a conscript army cut across all the divides of German society; though

¹⁵ Markus Leniger, *Nationalsozialistische "Volkstumsarbeit" und Umsiedlungspolitik, 1933–1945. Von der Minderheitenbetreuung zur Siedlerauslese* (Leipzig: Frank & Timme, 2011); Gerhard Wolf, *Ideologie und Herrschaftsrationalität. Nationalsozialistische Germanisierungspolitik in Polen* (Hamburg: Hamburger Edition, 2012); Maria Fiebrandt, *Auslese für die Siedlergesellschaft. Die Einbeziehung Volksdeutscher in die NS-Erbgesundheitspolitik im Kontext der Umsiedlung, 1939–1945* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2014).

¹⁶ "Table Talk 24: 25 September 1941, midday," in Trevor-Roper, *Hitler's Table Talk*, 33.

¹⁷ "Table Talk 24: 25 September 1941, midday," in Trevor-Roper, *Hitler's Table Talk*, 33.

¹⁸ Theodor Oberländer, "Völkische Sozialpolitik und unsere Ostaufgabe," *Deutsche Monatshefte. Zeitschrift für Geschichte und Gegenwart des Ostdeutschtums* 7, no. 9–10 (1941): 365.

¹⁹ Oberländer, "Völkische Sozialpolitik und unsere Ostaufgabe," 369.

²⁰ The literature on Nazi policy toward psychologically disabled veterans is now quite voluminous. For a brief introduction to veterans' experiences, see Jason Crouthamel, "Nervous Nazis: War Neurosis, National Socialism and the Memory of the First World War," *War and Society* 21, no. 2 (2003); Jason Crouthamel, *The Great War and German Memory: Society, Politics and Psychological Trauma, 1914–1945* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2009), 189–219.

²¹ This relates to the social process of becoming disabled rather than equating physical impairment with disability. What is considered disabled varies temporally, spatially, and is situationally dependent. See Lennard J. Davis, "Introduction: Disability, Normality, and Power," in *The Disability Studies Reader*, ed. Lennard J. Davis (New York: Routledge, 2013), 1–16; Colin Barnes, "Understanding the Social Model of Disability: Past Present, and Future," in *Routledge Handbook of Disability Studies*, ed. Nick Watson et al. (London: Routledge, 2014), 12–29.

all these men had fought in the Nazi project for supremacy, though all had sacrificed their corporeal wholeness in this pursuit, though all had occupied the role of soldier, settlement standards deemed many unfit to help bring about the utopic German future in the East. Matthew Stibbe has noted that “there are some limits to what gender can explain, especially as the Third Reich prioritized race over gender when it came to reordering German and European society.”²² The Nazis sought not soldiers, the ostensible masculine ideal, but rather *German* soldiers who would be able-bodied *enough* to settle the East.

Idealizing the Disabled Racial Colonist (1942)

The order to settle the war-disabled came as Nazi Germany approached its territorial zenith and as Himmler began to speak of a greater Germanic Reich rather than merely a greater German Reich. The settlement of disabled veterans paved the way for an empire of Germanic blood (*germanisches Blut*) under German leadership (*deutsche Führung*), the selection of all Nordic-Germanic blood throughout Europe.²³ Himmler set the plan in motion on August 10, 1942, when he signed General Order 14/IV, the Preferential Settlement of the War-Disabled, War-Disabled of the World War, Fighters of the National Uprising, and Their Surviving Family Members in the Newly Acquired Areas of the German Reich.²⁴ Himmler circulated the order to the highest Reich authorities on September 14 and noted that he would begin drawing up detailed regulations for settlement operations and the application procedure.²⁵ On October 19, 1942, the order officially appeared across the Reich and announced that farmland and its mobile properties had been earmarked for disabled veterans in the incorporated eastern territories, Lower Styria, Upper Carniola, and Alsace-Lorraine.²⁶ Local and regional occupation authorities, the Wehrmacht, and Hermann Göring’s Main Trustee Office for the East (*Haupttreuhandstelle Ost*) all played roles in finding applicants and divvying up space for them in the East. Himmler tasked the RKFDV with finding suitable farms and jobs for the settlers and coordinating with other agencies that took part in the process. The SS retained final approval on matters of racial fitness. The euphoria caused by the wide-scale destruction of reeling Soviet forces led to visions of massive territorial aggrandizement but also the possibility of precisely shaping the population that would people these spaces.

Accompanying the order were guidelines for the arduous process of applying for settlement, which included a time-intensive evaluation to racially certify settlers’ Germanness that operated against eagerness to expedite settlement. In the *Altreich*, the Nazi regime relied on the self-mobilization of ordinary Germans to investigate their family genealogies and to prove their racial membership in the *Volksgemeinschaft*.²⁷ Some undesired members, however, fell through the cracks. Records of descent might be incomplete; genealogies could be falsified. Thus, even for married applicants, the marriage certificate of hereditary health proved insufficient. Officials also rejected both the Aryan certificate (*Ariernachweis*), though it certified a German to work as officials of the government, and the Greater Aryan certificate (*Großer Ariernachweis*), proof enough for SS membership, as sufficient demonstration of

²² Matthew Stibbe, “In and Beyond the Racial State: Gender and National Socialism, 1933–1955,” *Politics, Religion, and Ideology* 13, no. 2 (2012): 159.

²³ Heinemann, “Rasse, Siedlung, deutsches Blut,” 419.

²⁴ Heinrich Himmler, Allgemeine Anordnung Nr. 14/IV über die bevorzugte Seßhaftmachung von Kriegsverwundeten, Kriegsdienstbeschädigten des Weltkrieges, Kämpfern der Nationalen Erhebung sowie deren Hinterbliebenen in den neuerworbenen Gebieten des Deutschen Reiches, August 10, 1942, in Bundesarchiv (BArch) NS 6/338.

²⁵ Letter from the Office of the Reichsführer-SS to the Highest Reich Authorities, September 14, 1942, in BArch R 2/13919.

²⁶ NSDAP Party Chancellory, Rundschreiben Nr. 161/42, October 19, 1942, in BArch NS 6/338.

²⁷ This process is best documented in Eric Ehrenreich, *The Nazi Ancestral Proof: Genealogy, Racial Science, and the Final Solution* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2007).

examination process, and in apparent contradiction to propaganda, a motley group of disabled veterans *de facto* assumed the mantle of ideal racial colonist, if only for a brief time.

Cataclysm (October 1944)

Neither for the intended purpose of becoming *Wehrbauern* nor as the economic expediency of business owners and industrial workers did disabled veterans make the impact in the East that the regime hoped they would. In July 1943, just as settlement got into full swing, manpower shortages began demanding the return of disabled Waffen-SS and *Ordnungspolizei* men who had settled in the Latvian agricultural sector. Rather than serving as *Wehrbauern*, these men were transferred to administrative and clerical positions throughout the Reich in agencies that conscription had hollowed out. The SS's commissioner general of Riga promised the men they would receive official certification for their experience so that it would count toward their agricultural apprenticeships and any agricultural vocational training they registered for after their return to the East after their service to the war effort ended.⁸⁷ Dreams of eastern settlement had not ended after Stalingrad, nor by the middle of 1943, as some disabled veterans began to return even as others settled.

Institutions continued to operate until Soviet soldiers plucked each hectare of colonial farmland away. The RKFDV and VoMi shuffled *Volksdeutsche* settlers farther west as security proved inadequate and the colonists "became targets for terrorist attacks, and ... partisan bands raided German settlements with impunity."⁸⁸ Resettlement (*Umsiedlung*) was now referred to as rehousing or relocation, but with more than a hint of "evacuation" (*Umquartierung*).⁸⁹ The SS gave up on using settled disabled veterans as protection for the *Volksdeutsche*, but these *Wehrbauern* and their families were not evacuated west with the *Volksdeutsche*. They would provide the rear-guard action of manning the border as the Soviets drove the Wehrmacht back. Some of the writing had been on the wall since October 1943 when Warthegau leaders had decided that *Stufe I*, the least disabled veterans, should not yet settle until after the war because they were likely to be recalled to some kind of service.⁹⁰ Some disabled veterans had already been called back to service mere months prior to that meeting. By October 1944, even more had been called back to service. The SS now scrambled to employ the *Wehrbauern* for one last combat mission in Danzig/West Prussia: to protect the wives and children on the farms of those disabled veterans who had been called up. Because it was only the lightly disabled who had been conscripted again, the SS hoped to employ the more severely disabled for this task. The SS claimed the disabled veterans would provide "economic care," but admitted that this would be unlikely, considering that, though they were mostly young men, they were all amputees who would be unable to provide much productive farm labor.⁹¹ The SS requested a list of women most in need of economic care—but the designation was a circumlocution for physical security. A week later, the SS ordered the local agencies to provide the list immediately.⁹² The dire military situation probably prompted the exhortation: the Soviets had captured the important city of Riga the day before, and on the day the letter was written Soviet forces began a major offensive to penetrate the borders of East Prussia itself. The local police leader listed twenty-four locations that needed the aid of a disabled veteran; only sixteen men were scraped together to provide the defense.⁹³ During the back and

⁸⁷ Letter from SS Commissioner General in Riga to Commissioner of the Mitau Area, July 14, 1943, in BArch R 91/202.

⁸⁸ Lumans, *Himmler's Auxiliaries*, 197.

⁸⁹ Koehl, *RKFDV*, 174.

⁹⁰ "Guidelines for Special Cases for the Settlement of Reichsgau Wartheland," October 22, 1943, in BArch R 49/3137.

⁹¹ Letter from RuSHA to Police Leader Weichsel, October 10, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42.

⁹² Letter from RuSHA to Police Leader Weichsel, October 16, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42.

⁹³ Letter from Police Leader Weichsel to RuSHA, November 1, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42; letter from SS Detachment XXXXI to Police Leader Weichsel, November 15, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42.

forth lasting more than a month, Wehrmacht forces temporarily stymied Soviet operations into the Polish colonies.

But many disabled veteran settlers had lost their farms to the encroaching Soviet army. Disabled SS man Jerke began a tour of the Gotenhafen region in northern Poland to find these men temporary work positions. Jerke was not picky and visited seven local firms and farms that might employ the men. All seven refused, citing lack of sleeping accommodations and the fact that they were already caring for other suffering men.⁹⁴ Others occasionally offered to lend a hand; a Director Lorenz offered forty positions for disabled Wehrmacht and SS veterans who had been driven from the East.⁹⁵ These forty positions would provide “training of the farmers to become managers in order to have effective specialists at hand when the East is regained.”⁹⁶ An interesting rationale at the end of October 1944. The men who had conquered the East, who had applied for and been selected to colonize it, were now refugees, beset by the forces over which they were to have reigned. Settling the East had come to an end.

Actual practice and implementation had ground roughly against ideology. The euphoria of victory in 1941 and 1942 elicited plans for the settlement of vast tracts of land in the East. But elusive military victory continually deferred constructing the living wall of able-bodied veterans with front-line experience. In fact, it was the military setbacks, the blood-letting in the Soviet Union, that both caused the problem and delivered its solution. Able-bodied veterans could not man the wall until victory over the Soviets; vicious warfare against the Soviets produced the disabled bodies that would garrison the East in the meantime. Yet, the more disabled bodies the war produced, the fewer able-bodied soldiers remained to win the war. Nazi Germany never managed to break the cycle. The inability to break the cycle resulted in much more than the substitution of able-bodied veterans with their disabled counterparts. Nazi ideology and propaganda advanced the soldier as the ideal masculine role for men. Yet the *Wehrmacht* was composed mostly of men conscripted from a pool of German citizens, including men of questionable political beliefs and, more perniciously, men whose blood might be tainted by Polish or even Jewish ancestry. Extensive racial examinations purportedly provided Nazi Germany with the ability to ensure the racial purity of the nascent, superior German race blooming in the East. Theoretically, the Nazis had a chance to sculpt the race as they saw fit. The able-bodied veteran with a record of proven soldierly deeds and a certificate of confirmed racial purity in hand—a veritable superman by Nazi standards—would become the model Germans that racial inferiors on the other side of the living wall would fear and that *Volksdeutsche* would emulate. As the atrocious feed-back loop cycled through, the regime opted for disabled veterans to assume the role of racial colonist, broken as they might be by Nazi body standards.

The substitution challenged Nazi ideology in profound ways, and the host of settlement authorities wrangled with one another to iron out the boundaries to decide which disabled veterans might assume the mantle of ideal racial colonist in the East. Demarcating racial boundaries resulted in disabled veterans with Polish ancestry being held up as model Germans to “full-blooded” *Volksdeutsche*. So long as the veterans did not have “too much” Polish blood. The confines of gender, sexuality, and masculinity shifted to include men who had previously been prosecuted for homosexual acts, as long as they married women and produced babies for the colonization effort. Able-bodiedness itself was redefined in the Eastern context as settlement authorities authorized men with brain trauma, blindness, or missing limbs to join the colonial project, provided that they contributed to the economic productivity and protection of the budding eastern *Volksgemeinschaft*. In lieu of able-bodied front-line veterans, all of these physically impaired men, men outside or on the fringes of

⁹⁴ Letter from Police Leader Weichsel to RuSHA, November 17, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42.

⁹⁵ “Aktenvermerk. Besichtigung der Dienststelle durch Hstuf. Hempel,” October 27, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42.

⁹⁶ “Aktenvermerk. Besichtigung der Dienststelle durch Hstuf. Hempel,” October 27, 1944, in BArch NS 47/42.

Nazi ideological acceptance, joined the utopian project as the racial colonist of the East. Nazi propaganda broadcast an ideological world of binaries: racially pure/impure, heterosexual/homosexual, and able-bodied/disabled. The realities and contingencies of war exposed the instability of these categories as Nazi officials scrambled to shore up the coherence of Nazi ideology and the legibility of its disabled veterans. Settlement officials exhorted disabled veterans to protect the women and children settlers marooned in a dying, ideological dream. Total defeat ended officials' struggles to find coherence, but for settlers the dream of colonization ended in a very real and material way in flight or bloodshed.

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Christopher Thomas Goodwin is a PhD candidate in the History Department at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign. He is currently completing his dissertation, "Broken Supermen: Disabled Veterans and Soldiers in Nazi Germany, 1939–1945." He recently published his article "What Difference Does a (Disabled) Husband Make? Disabled Veterans, Women, and the Limits of Population Policy in the Third Reich," in the *Journal of Family History*, and his other work has appeared in *War and Society*, *Programming Historian*, *Journal of Military History*, *German Politics and Society*, and various edited collections.

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